

IT'S IN OUR DNA

The process of mutation plays a vital role in evolution by introducing random changes to DNA, the self-replicating biochemical molecule that carries instructions for making living things. Mutations involve individual chemical units called “bases” (the individual letters of the DNA code) abruptly changing from one form to another. Because bases seem inherently stable, some scientists think that quantum tunneling (see pp.70–71) is needed to leap energy barriers within their structure and allow them to change.

